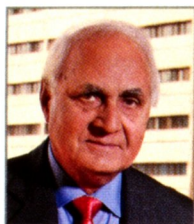


THINK BIG NOW

It is time to overhaul our real estate vision and allow the private sector to play a constructive role in urban development



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Perfect urban infrastructure is where basic civic amenities for healthy living are made available before the actual construction of dwelling units. This does not exist in developing countries easily. In India particularly, it is far from satisfactory.

This happened due to a major mistake made by our leaders post-Independence. The urban infrastructure and real estate sector remained neglected as we were banking on the planning concepts as envisaged by the socialist regime in the former USSR, despite our noble intentions. India started developing rapidly and failed to keep up with then available infrastructure. The philosophy of thinking small and managing shortages through government control led to a catastrophic mistake: thinking that urban housing needs could be met by the public sector. The government not only banned the involvement of the private sector, but brought in the Urban Land Ceiling Act in 1976.

From the 1960s through the '90s, when housing demand was galloping, things were taken care of by the public sector. As a result, a new breed of fly-by-night operators came in and connived with corrupt bureaucrats, technocrats, planners and politicians and it became

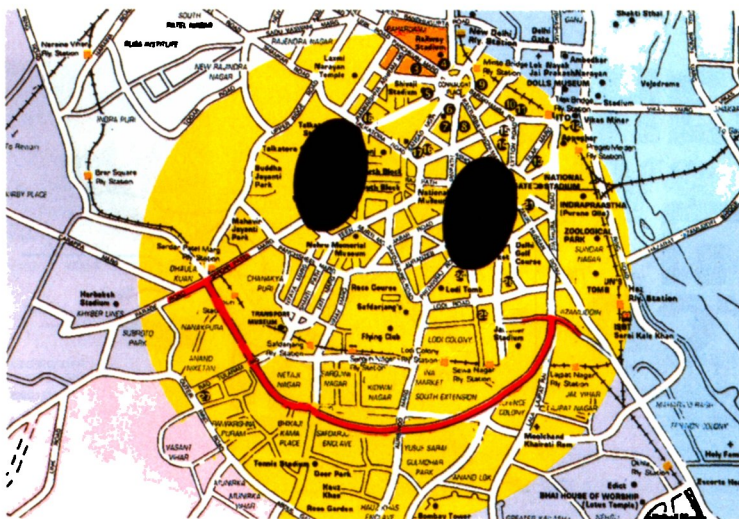
a mafia. Unauthorised places started to come up with total disregard to master plans and town planning, leading to haphazard development.

This prevailed till economic reforms were unleashed. Then development started catching up. Naturally, the first requirement of people was better living. However, urban infrastructure needs were not forecasted properly due to a faulty system of education and vision. Take the Delhi-Gurgaon Highway. The day it was opened, it got choked. What kind of planning is that? Maybe three lanes aren't enough. It should have had six or eight lanes on either side.

Needs today are gigantic. They may not have been so had they been planned better then. Another reason for faulty planning was the political system wooing the rural votebank and totally ignoring the urban. Now with migration from rural to urban, the urban votebank has increased considerably. This is putting pressure on the ill-organised municipal corporations. If they discard the old systems and plan for the future, they can do much better. Take buildings for instance. Why should there be a limit? Since you cannot go horizontal, go vertical.

This requires a massive change in outlook. If we start now, it will take a couple of decades. Too much damage has already happened. Proper planning in urban infrastructure is very important as you cannot undo mistakes. Once it is committed, generations will suffer. What will help:

- ▶ **Learn from the past** Government should adopt urban infrastructure policies based on lessons learnt from past policy failures.
- ▶ **Involve the private sector** Ensure that the public sector confines its role to a planner, regulator, enabler and facilitator, leaving development entirely to the private sector.
- ▶ **Bring radical change in educational systems** Include urban infrastructure in the curriculum in schools and colleges.
- ▶ **Respect the word profit** Distinguish it from profiteering.
- ▶ **A complete change in vision** Ensure future policy-makers think big and create surpluses against the earlier concept of thinking small and managing shortages. *as told to Nandini Vaish*



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